

THIRD SUNDAY OF EASTER - APRIL 26

Describe a time when you were expecting something you had high hopes for to happen and suddenly fell through, but then you received a surprise that made what you were hoping for become a reality. *Note: If you are with a group, have each person take a turn sharing.*

Scripture Reading: Luke 24:13-35

Now on that same day two of them were going to a village called Emmaus, about seven miles from Jerusalem, and talking with each other about all these things that had happened. While they were talking and discussing, Jesus himself came near and went with them, but their eyes were kept from recognizing him. And he said to them, "What are you discussing with each other while you walk along?" They stood still, looking sad. Then one of them, whose name was Cleopas, answered him, "Are you the only stranger in Jerusalem who does not know the things that have taken place there in these days?" He asked them, "What things?" They replied, "The things about Jesus of Nazareth, who was a prophet mighty in deed and word before God and all the people, and how our chief priests and leaders handed him over to be condemned to death and crucified him. But we had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel. Yes, and besides all this, it is now the third day since these things took place. Moreover, some women of our group astounded us. They were at the tomb early this morning, and when they did not find his body there, they came back and told us that they had indeed seen a vision of angels who said that he was alive. Some of those who were with us went to the tomb and found it just as the women had said; but they did not see him." Then he said to them, "Oh, how foolish you are, and how slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have declared! Was it not necessary that the Messiah should suffer these things and then enter into his glory?" Then beginning with Moses and all the prophets, he interpreted to them the things about himself in all the scriptures.

As they came near the village to which they were going, he walked ahead as if he were going on. But they urged him strongly, saying, "Stay with us, because it is almost evening and the day is now nearly over." So he went in to stay with them. When he was at the table with them, he took bread, blessed and broke it, and gave it to them. Then their eyes were opened, and they recognized him; and he vanished from their sight. They said to each other, "Were not our hearts burning within us while he was talking to us on the road, while he was opening the scriptures to us?" That same hour they got up and returned to Jerusalem; and they found the eleven and their companions gathered together. They were saying, "The Lord has risen indeed, and he has appeared to Simon!" Then they told what had happened on the road, and how he had been made known to them in the breaking of the bread.

Reflection

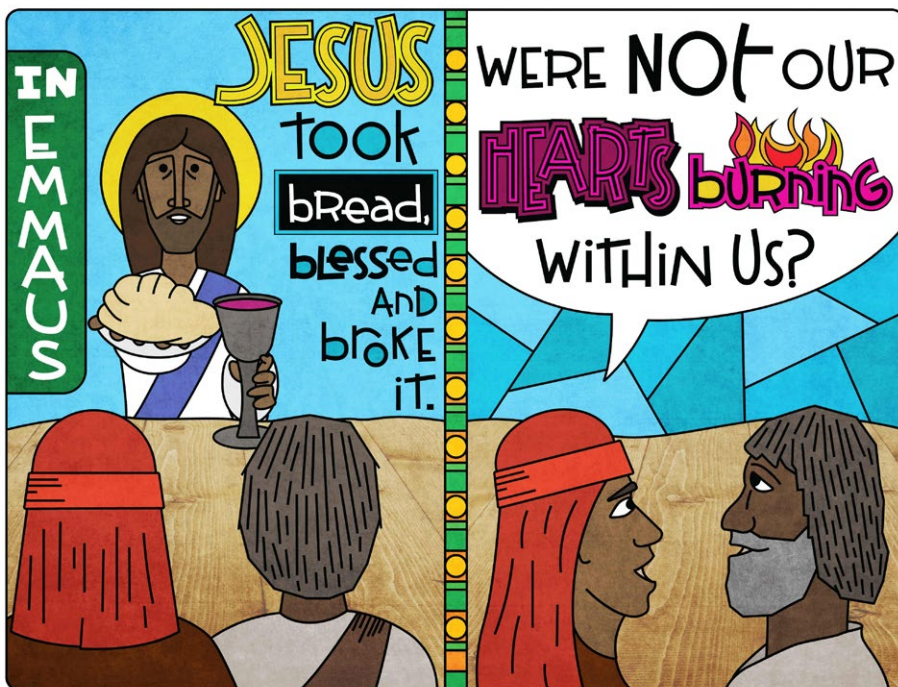
The disciples were sad and confused after Jesus died. As two of the disciples took a walk to a town called Emmaus, they talked about all the things they experienced since their friend's death. Talking about something painful, upsetting, or scary is one way to begin to understand what happened and how you feel about it.

As they walk and talk, Jesus appears and joins them. The story tells us their eyes kept them from recognizing him. Perhaps they were so filled with sadness they weren't able to recognize him. Or maybe after all the suffering Jesus went through, he changed in ways his friends weren't able to identify. Suffering has a way of changing us.

Jesus asks them what they've been talking about. Shocked that there could be a person who didn't know the biggest news of the day, the two tell Jesus what happened. They also shared how Jesus' death shattered their hopes for a new life because Jesus was supposed to be the one who brought freedom to the people. And to make matters even more confusing, they hear that some of the women went to the tomb, found it was empty, and claimed to see angels announcing he's alive!?

As Jesus takes a turn to share, he tells them Jesus' suffering and death is not the end. Remember, they still don't recognize him. This suffering Jesus experienced, that they are experiencing, did, and will continue to create new life. He reminds them that there is a pattern in the stories from scripture - from suffering, new life begins.

Perplexed, a bit in awe, and perhaps even finding comfort with someone who felt familiar, they begged for him to stay for dinner. At the meal, the risen Jesus took the bread, blessed it, broke it, and gave it to them. It was an action they knew all too well. As soon as they recognized him, he vanished before their eyes.



Luke 24:13-35 • illustratedministry.com

No wonder he felt familiar, and it felt like their hearts were burning as Jesus talked with them on the road! As soon as that joy overtook them, they ran back to the rest of the disciples to say all the good work Jesus had done, all the suffering he went through doesn't end here. The risen Jesus has appeared to them, and they must continue to bring God's promise of new life to the world.

As we are in the midst of suffering and grief, much like the disciples were when they were walking down the road to Emmaus, many of our expectations and hopes have been broken or even shattered. Some of us have felt the deep pain from the death of loved ones because of the novel coronavirus. We don't quite know when the end of the COVID-19 pandemic will be in sight. What we do know is that from suffering comes new life and transformation. In our suffering, let us remember that new life appeared to the disciples, and it will appear to us as well.

Discussion Questions

1. What was your favorite part of this story, or what part resonated with you?
2. What signs of new life are you seeing right now?
3. In what ways are you able to help care for the new life that is appearing now?

Prayer

Dear God, thank you for this story and for teaching us that through suffering, new life will come. Help us to be gentle with each other in our suffering and show us signs of new life. **Amen.**

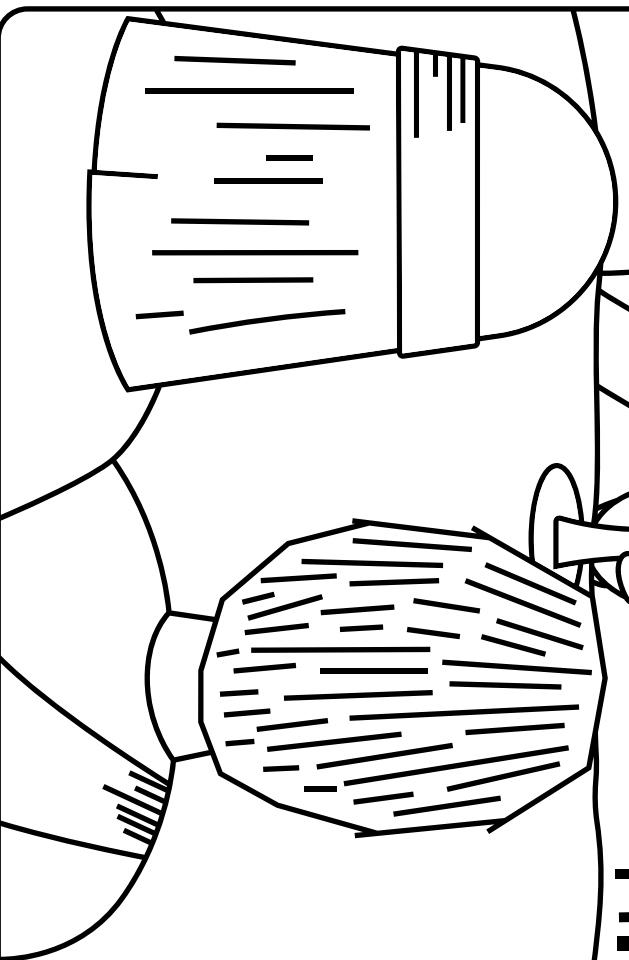
THE SCAM

JESUS

took

bread,

blessed
and
broke
it.



WERE NOT OUR

HEARTS  BURNING

WITHIN US?



COLOR IN THE WORDS

WEREN'T OUR

FEARS

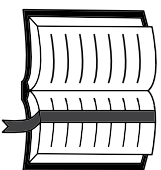
ON

THE

WEEK

WHICH

SPoke
to US



illustrated
— MINISTRY —

Suggested for use on the Third Sunday of Easter based on the RCL.
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CHILDREN'S WORSHIP • BULLETIN

Activities based on Psalm 16: 14, 12-19, Luke 24: 13-35.

I SHALL lift UP

the CUP of

STRAIGHT

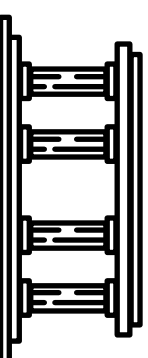
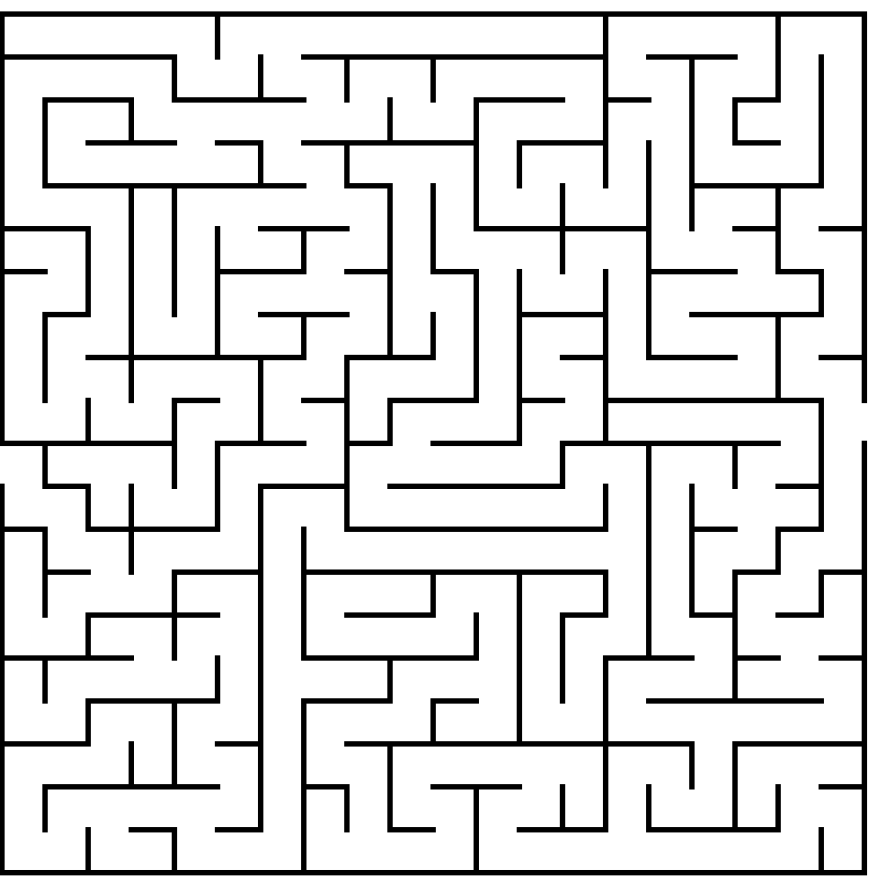
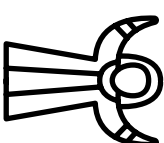


DRAW IT

In Luke 24, Jesus appears to his disciples on the Emmaus Road. The disciples do not recognize Jesus or know that it's him. They still think he is dead. But when Jesus talks with them, something amazing happens in their hearts. They say their hearts felt like they were on "fire," and that they knew it must have been Jesus talking to them. Draw what you would feel like if Jesus appeared to you. What would your heart feel like? Has something like this ever happened to you before?

SOLVE (the) MAZE

The Psalmist says she will keep promises to God in the presence of all God's people. Help her find her way to the Lord's courtyards so she can share this hopeful message.



THINKING OF YOU • COLOR & SHARE

Physical distancing is hard, isn't it? We don't get to see our friends, our grandparents, our extended family. When you miss your friends from school, your church friends, and your work friends, what ways do you let them know you're thinking of them during this challenging COVID-19 time?

One way you can let them know is by using this "Thinking of You" coloring page (adapted from one of our digital greeting cards). Print this sheet and color and cut out the "Thinking of You" coloring page below. Then take a picture of it and text it to a friend, or email it, or share it on social media. Maybe you could send one to a school teacher, or a Sunday School teacher, and let them know you are thinking of them. Or maybe your piano teacher. Or your grandparents, or other significant grown-ups in your life. However you use it, we hope you enjoy bringing some color and hope into someone's day.

